

Amazon Echo

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Course Code: BTH605 NAA

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April 7, 2025

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Introduction

Amazon Echo is virtual assistant that utilizes its network connectivity to provide real time services with the use of Artificial Intelligence. As Amazon Echo uses the internet and can manage other smart devices, it falls under the classification of an IoT device as it can connect to the internet for services as well as other devices to perform actions, collect information or general connection. Below, you can find an image followed by a video showcase.



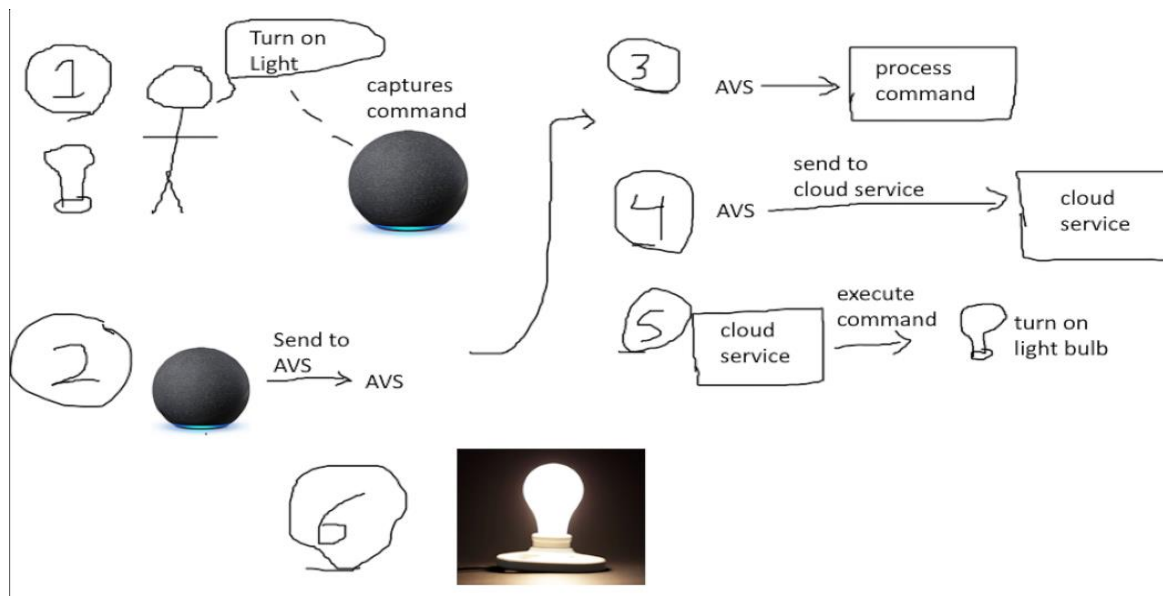
One of the more recent designs and developments of Echo.

Video Showcase:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zmhcPKKt7gw>

How Does Amazon Echo Work

Amazon Echo utilizes a technology akin to IVR, specifically, they use AVS. IVR stands for Interactive Voice Response which is a way to allow users to provide information and requests interactively verbally without the need of gestures or screen-based interactions. Amazon Echo, however, uses AVS, Alexa Voice Service. This is an extension of IVR that allows Amazon Echo to be more tailored towards handling dynamic voice requests. This technology, AVS, will be referred to as Alexa from now on for simplicity is the technology used to handle and process requests. When the user makes a request, the IoT, Amazon Echo, will capture the command and use some IoT Agent to pass the request to Alexa, which then will be processed by Alexa. Then, Alexa will send a request to a specific cloud service made to handle said request, which then the command is executed and handled. Below is a simple illustration of a user turning on a connected smart light bulb.

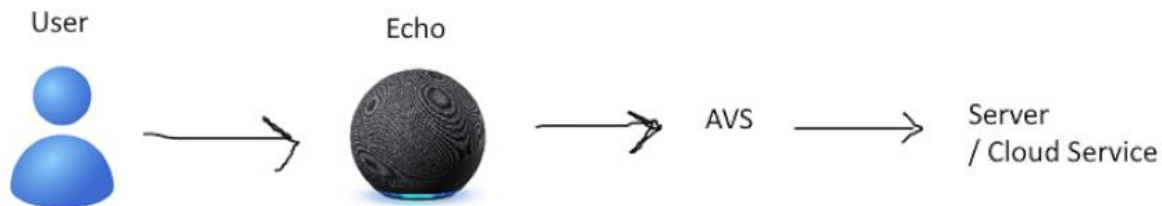


Amazon Echo Concept & Structure Implementation

Concept

Conceptually, the layers go as such: User, IoT Device, IoT Agent, Server. So, at the top, we have the user, which are the people who interact with Amazon Echo. They are the ones who give the commands to execute. They must be in range for the devices audio sensors for it to catch the users voice and command. Then, going down a layer we have the IoT Device, this is the Amazon Echo. It is the device that is not only capturing user commands but also is the one connected to other smart devices and connecting to the server via the IoT Agent. After, we have the IoT agent. This agent is AVS, Alexa Voice Service, it processes the command and will interact with the whichever cloud service to begin executing the command. Then, for the 'server' we have whatever cloud service is needed, AVS is the 'server' for processing commands whereas a specific cloud service is the 'server' for handling the command.

Structure:



To reiterate, the way this is implemented is by having the User represent the real consumer, the IoT device being Amazon Echo, the IoT Agent being AVS and the Server being the Cloud Service being used to execute the command from the User.

Considerations

Benefits:

Some major benefits are with the great design practices Amazon Echo comes with, such as, ambient display, affordance, simplicity and flexibility. Firstly, the minimalistic design of the Echo makes it intuitive for usage and by having a small glow when the device is listening allows for the user to easily understand and recognize when Echo is listening versus not. Then, for affordance, there are multiple types of amazon echo, so even if the newest is too expensive, there are multiple different types of Amazons Echo available at cheap prices like \$55 for one of the newest models. Finally, by having a very simple usage yet such a flexible usability makes for a great advantage. It's difficult to get errors as there is always a vocal response to help guide the users and appropriate responses for errors.

Concerns:

With such a simple UI, it can be difficult to setup as there isn't much information in how to use said device. Alongside this, they also run into the issue of having all their components too tightly coupled together. Each component in Echo is tightly coupled together and difficult to even view separately, so if a hardware issue arises, it is difficult for the average person to view and diagnose an issue.

Other Thoughts:

A large concern of Amazon Echo would be privacy and security. As it is listening often, it can often hear and remember sensitive information. As it utilizes the Cloud, information you may not want to be out may be saved/used in the Cloud outside of your local area. Furthermore, the major security issue lies in Echo collecting users' interactions with Alexa, where they may even record your voice history of commands or other interactions. So, there is a security concern where if you use Echo, you will have your conversations with Echo recorded and kept.

Conclusion:

Overall, Amazon Echo is a IoT device that utilizes a custom version of IVR through AVS. It has a simple design that is affordable, has an ambient design and is flexible but has their components too tightly coupled together. Despite the security concern of recording conversations with it, it is a highly flexible and smart IoT device.

References

(General Info about Amazon Echo)

[https://www.techtarget.com/searchaws/definition/Amazon-Echo#:~:text=Using%20artificial%20intelligence%20\(AI\)%20and,setting%20a%20timer%20or%20alarm.](https://www.techtarget.com/searchaws/definition/Amazon-Echo#:~:text=Using%20artificial%20intelligence%20(AI)%20and,setting%20a%20timer%20or%20alarm.)

(image)

[https://www.techtarget.com/searchaws/definition/Amazon-Echo#:~:text=Using%20artificial%20intelligence%20\(AI\)%20and,setting%20a%20timer%20or%20alarm.](https://www.techtarget.com/searchaws/definition/Amazon-Echo#:~:text=Using%20artificial%20intelligence%20(AI)%20and,setting%20a%20timer%20or%20alarm.)

(video)

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zmhcPKKt7gw>

(About IVR)

<https://aws.amazon.com/what-is/interactive-voice-response/>

(Amazon Echo for \$55 for one of the latest models)

https://www.amazon.ca/Echo-Pop-with-Alexa/dp/B09WNK39JN/ref=asc_df_B09WNK39JN?mcid=cc09f8098bf63051801f53274cb1bd0d&hvadid=706747775008&hvpos=&hvnetw=g&hvrnd=1746191014900963746&hvpone=&hvptwo=&hvmmt=&hvdev=c&hvdvcmdl=&hvlocint=&hvlocphy=9195454&hvtargid=pla-2187527569390&psc=1&gad_source=1

(Amazon Echo records conversations)

<https://arstechnica.com/gadgets/2025/03/everything-you-say-to-your-echo-will-be-sent-to-amazon-starting-on-march-28/>